



# THERE ARE ABOUT SEVEN MILLION ALBANIANS living around the ALBANIANS

## PREPARING FOR A BRIGHT FUTURE

Adriatic Sea, less than half of whom live in Albania itself. Albanians form the majority in Kosovo, and large numbers also live in Macedonia,

### Many religions, one nationality

Religion never divided the Albanian people. In fact, Albania was the only country during World War II that managed not only to save their own Jews from the Nazis, but also to save the Jews from neighboring countries who fled to Albania. Since communist rule ended, Albania has been trying to find a way to accommodate religious practices within a secular state.



#### YOUNG PEOPLE

Education in Albania is compulsory between the ages of six and 14. Albania is still a very poor country, so conditions in schools are often very basic, with many even lacking adequate toilets. Polls suggest that many young Albanians would like to emigrate, but confidence in the future of the country is growing as conditions get better.

#### MUSLIM MAJORITY

Seventy percent of Albanians are Muslim, 20 percent are Orthodox Christian, and 10 percent are Roman Catholic. All mosques and churches were closed and religious observances forbidden under communism from 1967 to 1990. They are undergoing a cautious revival now.



#### ANCIENT ROOTS

Christianity came early to Albania. Saint Paul, one of the religion's founders, came to preach in the area in the first century AD.



#### THE ADRIATIC COAST

At their closest point, Albania and Italy are separated by less than 30 m (50 km) of sea. Apart from its coastline, Albania is largely a rocky and mountainous place. This may explain why 19th century European explorers always regarded it as a mysterious, impenetrable country.

